

Reservations

Starting with a pilot project in New Delhi in 1985, the computerized PRS system, based on a software developed indigenously by Computer Maintenance Corporation (CMC) for the Indian Railways brought about a revolution. Passengers no longer had to face long queues to get to the reservation desk and the clerk at the counter was freed of cumbersome, lengthy ledgers. It increased staff productivity and administered speed and accuracy into the system. Computerization did not have an adverse effect on labour relations either, with no downsizing of staff. On the contrary, the use of advanced applications and opening up of more counters in remote locations created more demand for a skilled workforce.

The implications of the success of PRS was huge. Academic and author V Rajaraman in "History of Computing in India, 1955–2010" noted that "there was an attitudinal change among both the general public and the white collar workers about computerization. This was the beginning of the acceptance of computers and the realization that in a country which has large volumes of data to be processed the use of computers is inevitable."

Legislation

In 1973, the Government recognized the obsolescence of the Indian Railways Act, 1890, and the few amendments that had been made to it since its enforcement. The minister of railways mentioned in the Budget of 1973–74 that "the objective is to bring this old statute into accord with the present day conditions and make it a more flexible instrument of regulation." Changes were sought in many sections, including compensation for accident victims and incidents related to unwarranted chain pulling, trespassing, and destruction of railway property and equipment. By 1977, a second draft was formulated "keeping in view the changed circumstances in which Indian Railways have to function in free India." By 1978, the final draft of a Bill for re-enactment of the Indian Railways Act was completed and placed for review with the Ministry of Law. Following due process, the Act came into force from 1990. The Railways Act, 1989, lays down comprehensive